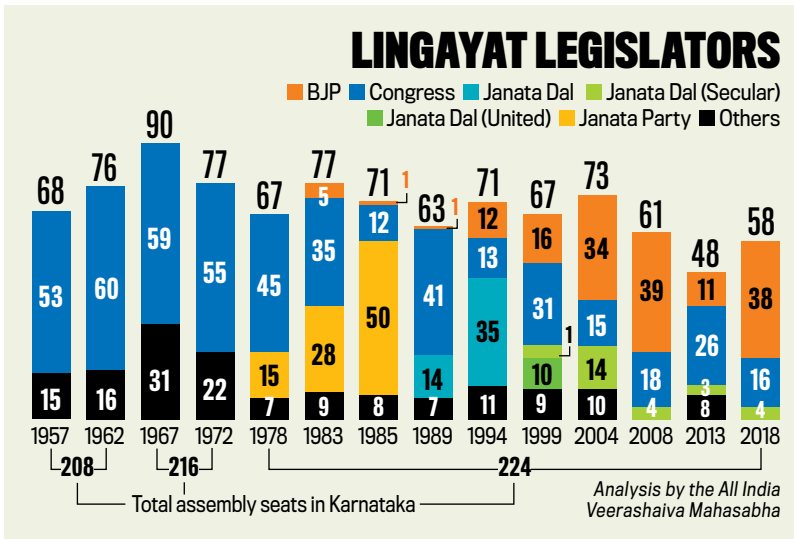


IN POLL MODE
B.S. Yediyurappa with PM Narendra Modi at the inauguration of the Shivamogga airport

ANI



Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

of 2008, when the party first came to power, its tally of Lingayat MLAs had reached an all-time high of 39 and Yediyurappa's stature was cemented for good. Hence, in 2021, while replacing him with Bommai, the party was careful in choosing a fellow Lingayat. Unfortunately, Bommai doesn't fit into the mass leader mould of his predecessor and so, heading into the election, the BJP is essentially falling back on the popularity of its old warhorse.

However, with Yediyurappa out of the reckoning in the electoral race, the Congress, too, is eyeing a fair chance to reclaim the community's support. If the BJP is decrying the Congress for treating its Lingayat leaders shabbily, the latter retorts that the BJP has hardly been respectful to Yediyurappa. "They have removed Yediyurappa very unceremoniously, insulting him. The sentiment is definitely there," says Eshwar Khandre, working president of the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee and also the secretary-general of the All India Veerashaiva Mahasabha. Whenever Lingayat leaders have led the Congress, the party has 'won handsomely'.

However, back in 1983, the Lingayats had drifted towards the Janata Party. The land reforms brought in by the Congress under D. Devaraj Urs had alienated the landed communities. The Janata Party remained in power until 1989, when Patil led the Congress to a thumping victory, winning 178 of Karnataka's 224 assembly seats. Of the 63 Lingayat legislators in that year, 41 had won on a Congress ticket. But Patil suffered a paralytic stroke in 1990, and Rajiv Gandhi, then Congress president, replaced him with the popular backward classes leader S. Bangarappa. This dismissal, announced at the Bengaluru airport on his way back after visiting the ailing Patil, marked a climactic moment in Karnataka's political history. The Lingayat backlash at the 'betrayal' was evident in the Congress defeat in 1994 and, in the popular reckoning, the Congress has never regained the support of